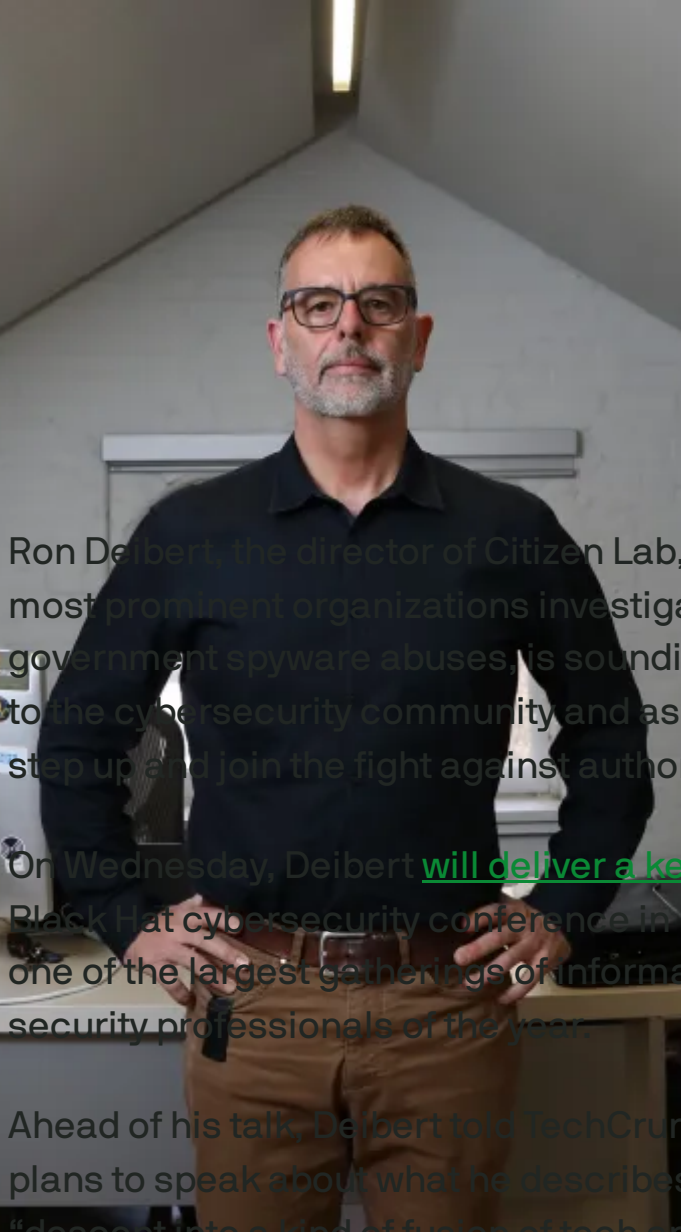


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Citizen Lab director warns cyber industry about US authoritarian descent



Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

— 8:01 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

Ron Deibert, the director of Citizen Lab, one of the most prominent organizations investigating government spyware abuses, is sounding the alarm to the cybersecurity community and asking them to step up and join the fight against authoritarianism.

On Wednesday, Deibert will deliver a keynote at the Black Hat cybersecurity conference in Las Vegas, one of the largest gatherings of information security professionals of the year.

Ahead of his talk, Deibert told TechCrunch that he plans to speak about what he describes as a “descent into a kind of fusion of tech and fascism,” and the role that the Big Tech platforms are playing, and “propelling forward a really frightening type of collective insecurity that isn’t typically addressed by this crowd, this community, as a cybersecurity problem.”

Deibert described the recent political events in the United States as a “dramatic descent into authoritarianism,” but one that the cybersecurity community can help defend against.

“I think alarm bells need to be rung for this community that, at the very least, they should be aware of what’s going on and hopefully they can not contribute to it, if not help reverse it,” Deibert told TechCrunch.

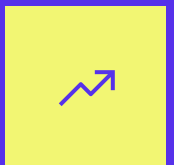
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Historically, at least in the United States, the cybersecurity industry has put politics — to a certain extent — to the side. More recently, however, politics has fully entered the world of cybersecurity.

Earlier this year, President Donald Trump [ordered an investigation into former CISA director Chris Krebs](#), who had publicly rebuffed Trump’s false claims about election fraud by declaring the 2020 election secure. Trump later [fired Krebs by tweet](#). The investigation ordered by Trump months after his 2024 reelection forced Krebs to [step down from SentinelOne and vow to fight back](#).

In response, Jen Easterly, another former CISA director and Krebs’ successor, [called on the cybersecurity community to get involved](#) and speak out.

“If we stay silent when experienced, mission-driven leaders are sidelined or sanctioned, we risk something greater than discomfort; we risk diminishing the very institutions we are here to protect,” Easterly wrote in a post on LinkedIn.

Easterly was herself [a victim of political pressure](#) from the Trump administration when her offer to join West Point was rescinded in late July.

Deibert, who this year [published his new book](#), “Chasing Shadows: Cyber Espionage, Subversion, and the Global Fight for Democracy,” is echoing the same message as Easterly.

“I think that there comes a point at which you have to recognize that the landscape is changing around you, and the security problems you set out for yourselves are maybe trivial in light of the broader context and the insecurities that are being propelled forward in the absence of proper checks

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and balances and oversight, which are deteriorating,” said Deibert.

Deibert is also concerned that big companies like Meta, Google, and Apple could take a step back in their efforts to fight against government spyware — [sometimes referred](#) to as “commercial” or “mercenary” spyware — by gutting their threat intelligence teams.

These threat intelligence teams are dedicated groups of security researchers that track government hackers, both those working inside government agencies, such as China’s Ministry of State Security or Russia’s intelligence agencies FSB and GRU, and companies such as NSO Group or Paragon.

These are the same teams that are responsible for detecting hacks against their own users, such as when [WhatsApp caught NSO Group](#) hacking more than 1,400 of its users in 2019, or when Apple caught hackers using government spyware to target its customers and [notified the victims](#) of the [attacks](#).

Deibert believes there is a “huge market failure when it comes to cybersecurity for global civil society,” a part of the population that generally cannot afford to get help from big security companies that typically serve governments and corporate clients. “This market failure is going to get more acute as supporting institutions evaporate and attacks on civil society amplify,” he said.

“Whatever they can do to contribute to offset this market failure (e.g., pro bono work) will be essential to the future of liberal democracy worldwide,” he said.

Deibert is concerned that these threat intelligence teams could be cut or at least reduced, given that the same companies have cut their moderation and safety teams.

He told TechCrunch that threat intelligence teams, like the ones at Meta, are doing “amazing work,” in part by staying siloed and separate from the commercial arms of their wider organizations.

“But the question is how long will that last?” said Deibert.

Topics: [black hat](#) [Black Hat 2025](#) [Citizen Lab](#)

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Hackers exploiting SharePoint zero-day seen targeting government agencies

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

— 12:42 PM PDT · July 21, 2025

The hackers behind the [initial wave of attacks exploiting a zero-day in Microsoft SharePoint servers](#) have so far primarily targeted government organizations, according to researchers and news reports.

IMAGE CREDITS: BRYCE DURBIN / TECHCRUNCH

Over the weekend, U.S. cybersecurity agency CISA [published an alert](#), warning that hackers were exploiting a previously unknown bug — known as a “[zero-day](#)” — in Microsoft’s enterprise data management product SharePoint. While it’s still too early to draw definitive conclusions, it appears that the hackers who first started abusing this flaw were targeting government organizations, according to Silas Cutler, the principal researcher at Censys, a cybersecurity firm that monitors hacking activities on the internet.

“It looks like initial exploitation was against a narrow set of targets,” Cutler told TechCrunch. “Likely government related.”

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“This is a fairly rapidly evolving case. Initial exploitation of this vulnerability was likely fairly limited in terms of targeting, but as more attackers learn to replicate exploitation, we will likely see breaches as a result of this incident,” said Cutler.

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Do you have more information about these SharePoint attacks? We’d love to hear from you. From a non-work device and network, you can contact Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai securely on Signal at +1 917 257 1382, or via Telegram and Keybase @lorenzofb, or [email](#).

Now that the vulnerability is out there, and is still not fully patched by Microsoft, it’s possible other hackers that are not necessarily working for a government will join in and start abusing it, Cutler said.

Cutler added that he and his colleagues are seeing between 9,000 and 10,000 vulnerable SharePoint instances accessible from the internet, but that could change. Eye Security, which first [published the existence of the bug](#), reported seeing a similar number, saying its researchers scanned more than 8,000 SharePoint servers worldwide and found evidence of dozens of compromised servers.

Given the limited number of targets and the types of targets at the beginning of the campaign, Cutler explained, it is likely that the hackers were part of a government group, commonly known as an [advanced persistent threat](#).

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[The Washington Post reported](#) on Sunday that the attacks targeted U.S. federal and state agencies, as well as universities and energy companies, among other commercial targets.

Microsoft [said in a blog post](#) that the vulnerability only affects versions of SharePoint that are installed on local networks, and not the cloud versions, which means that each organization that deploys a SharePoint server needs to apply the patch or disconnect it from the internet.

Topics: [apt](#) [CISA](#) [cybersecurity](#) [hackers](#) [hacking](#)

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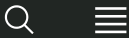
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U.S. cybersecurity agency CISA has warned that unknown hackers broke into the servers of a federal government agency by taking advantage of a previously known vulnerability in software that no longer receives updates — meaning the agency couldn't have patched it even if it wanted to.

On Tuesday, [CISA released an advisory](#) detailing two separate cyberattacks on an unnamed federal government agency. The hackers attacked the agency in June and July by targeting public-facing servers that were running outdated or end-of-life Adobe ColdFusion software, used for building web applications.

End-of-life software means that the developer has announced publicly it will no longer be supported or receive further software or security updates. Running end-of-life software is by definition risky because it cannot be patched, exposing the organization who runs the software to cyberattacks.

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Do you have more information about these attacks? Or other attacks targeting government agencies? We'd love to hear from you. You can contact Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai securely on Signal at +1 917 257 1382, or via Telegram, Keybase and Wire @lorenzofb, or email lorenzo@techcrunch.com. You also can contact TechCrunch via SecureDrop.

CISA said there is no evidence the attackers planted malware or did anything more than looking around in the hacked agency's network.

"Analysis suggests that the malicious activity conducted by the threat actors was a

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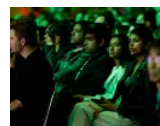
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reconnaissance effort to map the broader network,” but CISA conceded that it could not confirm if data was exfiltrated from the agency’s network.

CISA spokesperson Antonio Soliz declined to comment when asked by TechCrunch for more information on who the agency believes are the hackers responsible for targeting the agency.

In the advisory, CISA said it didn’t know if the two cyberattacks were performed by the same hackers.

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In both cyberattacks, Microsoft Defender for Endpoint, Windows' native antivirus software, alerted the agency to the potential exploitation of the Adobe ColdFusion vulnerability and "quarantined" the hackers' activities.

In March, CISA ordered all federal agencies to patch one of the known vulnerabilities in Adobe ColdFusion that were exploited in these attacks, [CVE-2023-26360](#).

UPDATE, December 6, 4:31 p.m. ET: This story was updated to include the no comment from CISA spokesperson.

Topics: [Adobe](#) [CISA](#) [cybersecurity](#) [hackers](#)

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Trump's cybersecurity cuts putting nation at risk, warns New York cyber chief

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

— 11:53 AM PDT · July 28, 2025

During the first few months of the new Trump administration, the White House slashed cybersecurity budgets, staff, and initiatives. And some, including [cybersecurity experts](#) and [legislators](#), are not happy about it.

One of them is [Colin Ahern](#), the chief cyber officer for the state of New York. In a recent interview with TechCrunch, Ahern said that both he and New York Governor Kathy Hochul are worried that the Trump administration's cuts to cybersecurity are putting the country at risk.

"We work with the federal government day in and day out. We need and want the federal government to be effective," Ahern told TechCrunch. "I think it's no secret that we are concerned about some of the things — many of the things, in fact — that we're seeing with the 'Big Ugly Bill,' with the rescissions

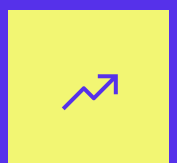
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that just passed,” said Ahern, referring to Trump’s flagship budget that passed in early July.

Trump’s cybersecurity cuts have been wide-ranging and far-reaching.

Since taking office, the Trump administration has [fired over a hundred employees](#) at CISA, some of whom the government [had to call back after a court ruling](#) reversed the decision. Trump’s One Big Beautiful Bill Act cut [cybersecurity spending](#) across federal agencies by more than \$1.2 billion, including cutting CISA’s [budget by](#) \$135 million, all the while [earmarking \\$1 billion over the next four years](#) for offensive cyber operations for overseas hacking operations.

Meanwhile, The White House’s [nomination](#) for national cyber director [was criticized](#) for his lack of prior experience in the field, and the U.S. Department of Education [suspended a cybersecurity support initiative](#) for K-12 schools.

“Everybody wants a federal government that has significant capabilities to deter our adversaries that is resilient against cyberattacks and other attacks from our enemies,” Ahern told TechCrunch. “Like we’ve said publicly, we do think that what’s happening in Washington is putting those things at risk.”

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While the U.S. federal government shoulders much
of the responsibility for the country's cybersecurity,
individual states share a significant mandate to
secure their own networks, state organizations like
public schools, as well as those of critical
infrastructure, such as water utilities. But some of
the funding for that comes from Washington.

Earlier this month, [Hochul wrote a letter to U.S.
Secretary of Homeland Security Kristi Noem](#) to ask
for funding available under the Homeland Security
Grant Program (HSGP), which provides state and
local agencies with funds to improve security both
in the real world and online.

"HSGP funding is vital to securing and maintaining
critical infrastructure assets (transportation hubs,
power grids, water systems, communication
networks)," wrote Hochul, who urged Noem to
make funds available "immediately."

While Ahern acknowledges the challenges with the
federal government, he said it doesn't mean the

state is “standing still.”

“We’re continuing to invest our time, our resources, and our energy in building relationships across state lines, across party lines, [and] relationships with our county and our local governments so that we can continue to provide the safe, resilient and affordable New York that we think has really made New York the cultural, financial, and economic center that it remains,” he said.

According to Ahern, Hochul has been vocal and active in her efforts to improve cybersecurity in New York.

Last month, [the governor signed new legislation](#) that will require anyone working with a computer in a state, city, county, or district government office in the state of New York to take cybersecurity awareness training. The law will also mandate state government offices that are victims of cyberattacks to report the incidents to the state’s homeland security office within 72 hours, and ransomware payments within 24 hours, among other provisions.

Last week, Hochul also [announced new proposed](#) regulations to start a new grant program for water and wastewater organizations with the goal of helping them fund upgrades that they will have to come up with to comply with upcoming regulations.

Ahern told TechCrunch that the state government is opening a new office in New York City to be staffed with several technologists, including cybersecurity personnel. Ahern said he hopes to recruit some who lost their jobs because of the Trump administration.

“DOGE says you’re fired. New York says you’re hired,” said Ahern, referring to the government’s public [slogan](#) for this hiring effort.

This story was corrected to clarify that Hochul announced regulations, not legislation, for the water and wastewater grant program in the 14th paragraph.

Topics: [CISA](#) [Colin Ahern](#) [cybersecurity](#) [DHS](#)

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